The Testimonials Module

For Non-Technical Team Members

What the Testimonial System Is

Testimonials are the proof on the website. They are the seller stories — some on video, some written — that show a visitor that real homeowners in their situation called Tarek Buys Houses and were glad they did. They sit between "this company says it buys houses fast" and "this company actually did it for someone like me."

The system does two things: it stores every seller story in one place, and it lets the team decide which stories appear on the website, in what order, and in which layout — without a developer touching the code.

All testimonial content lives in **Supabase** (our database and backend provider). The testimonials table holds the text — names, locations, quotes, situations, key takeaways. Two storage buckets hold the media: `testimonial-videos` for the video files and `testimonial-thumbnails` for the cover images. When someone visits a page with testimonials on it, the page pulls everything from Supabase in real time.

Two Kinds of Story

Kind	What It Is
Video	A seller recorded on camera. Needs a video file (or a YouTube link), a cover image, and a headline. Shown in a tall, phone-shaped frame with a play button.
Written	A seller's words in text. Needs a pull quote (the big line that gets highlighted), the full story, and a short reason they called. No media required.

Both kinds can also carry a short list of **key takeaways** — the bullet points that appear next to a story, like "Offer Saturday morning" or "Closed by Monday."

The Consent Line

Every testimonial section on the website automatically displays this disclaimer underneath it — nobody has to add it by hand:

> *"Every story shared with the seller's written consent. Results vary based on property condition, market factors, and individual circumstances. Not a guarantee of any particular outcome."*

That line is the reason written consent has to be on file before a story goes live. If we don't have it, the story doesn't get published.

The Three Layouts

The same pool of stories can be displayed three different ways. Each layout is a separate slot on the website, and you choose which stories go into each one.

1. Spotlight

What it looks like: A list of sellers down the left side that a visitor can click through, with the selected story shown large on the right. Underneath the list is a trust bar with the Google rating, BBB rating, and homes purchased. Headline on the page: *"Pick a Story That Sounds Like Yours."*

> ***Best when:*** *you have several stories and want visitors to find the one closest to their own situation. It also absorbs new stories without the layout changing — the list just gets longer.*

2. Featured

What it looks like: One bordered box — a single video story on the left, up to two written testimonials stacked on the right. Headline on the page: *"Real Stories from Real Homeowners."*

> ***Best when:*** *the library is small — one strong video plus two good written quotes. It only ever shows one video and two written stories no matter how many you assign to it.*

3. Editorial

What it looks like: Full-width story rows down the page, numbered "Story 01," "Story 02," and so on, each with the seller's badge and a few facts (format, consent status, why they called). Headline on the page: *"What sellers said after we closed."*

> ***Best when:*** *you want the stories to read like a magazine feature rather than a widget — more room per story, more detail.*

Where Testimonials Appear on the Website

Page	What's Shown	Notes
Homepage	All three layouts, stacked one after another	This is a temporary test setup so the team can compare the three designs side by side. Only one will stay.
About page	A fixed block of three YouTube videos plus three written quotes	This block is **not** connected to the admin panel — editing testimonials will not change it.
City / situation pages	The same fixed block as the About page	Also not connected to the admin panel. The written quotes swap between a Tampa set and a generic set depending on the city.

> **Important: two separate systems are live right now**
>
> The homepage runs on the database and reflects whatever you set in the admin panel. The About page and all city pages still run on an older hardcoded block. So if you add a testimonial in the admin panel and then check a city page, you won't see it — that's expected today, not a bug you should report. Bringing every page onto the same system is a planned change.

The Testimonials Admin Panel

URL: `tarekbuyshouses.com/admin/testimonials`

This is where you add stories, edit them, and decide where they appear. There are two tabs: **List** (managing the stories themselves) and **Sections** (deciding which stories go into which layout).

The Dashboard

Four stat cards sit at the top of the List tab:

- **Total** — every testimonial in the system, whatever its status
- **Published** — stories that are eligible to appear on the website
- **Drafts** — stories being worked on, not visible to the public
- **Featured** — stories marked with the star

Finding and Filtering

The toolbar narrows down what you're looking at:

- **Status tabs** — All / Published / Draft / Archived
- **Search** — type any keyword to match a seller's name, their location, or the text of their story
- **Scenario filter** — a dropdown built from whatever scenarios already exist (Divorce, Relocation, Foreclosure, Loss in family, and so on)

Each row in the table shows the seller's **name**, the **kind** (video or written), the **scenario**, a colored **status** badge (green published, yellow draft, gray archived), a **featured star** you can click to toggle, and a **Delete** action. Click anywhere else on the row to open the editor. The Name, Kind, Scenario, and Status columns are all sortable — click the header once for A–Z, again for Z–A, a third time to clear.

Creating a Testimonial

Click **New Testimonial**. The form opens with Written selected; switch to Video at the top if the story has footage. Fill in the fields for that kind, then Create. New stories are saved as **drafts**, so nothing goes live by accident.

Fields for every story

- **Name** — the seller's name as it should appear publicly (required)
- **Location** — e.g. "Stevenson Ranch, CA"
- **Scenario** — the situation in a couple of words, e.g. "Relocation" or "Loss in family". This is what the scenario filter and the story badges use, so keep the wording consistent with what's already there.
- **Status** — Draft, Published, or Archived
- **Body** — the seller's full story (required)
- **Rating** — 1 to 5
- **Market Slug** — ties the story to a city, e.g. `tampa`. Leave blank if it isn't city-specific.
- **Featured** — the checkbox that marks this as the headline video (see the caution below)
- **Points** — the key takeaways, added one line at a time

Video stories also need

- **Headline** — the big line shown next to the video, e.g. "A quick and fair cash sale"
- **Video** — either an uploaded file or a YouTube ID
- **Thumbnail** — the cover image shown before someone presses play
- **Poster URL** — an optional backup cover image

Written stories also need

- **Pull Quote** — the one sentence that gets displayed large. Pick the line that lands hardest.
- **Reason** — a short phrase for why they called, e.g. "Relocating to another state"

The Save button stays disabled until Name and Body are filled in, and while any upload is still running.

> **Before you edit an existing story: re-enter the key takeaways**
>
> There is a known bug in the editor right now. When you open an existing testimonial, the **Points** list opens empty even if that story already has takeaways saved — and saving then clears them from the database.
>
> Until this is fixed: if you open a story to change anything at all, re-type its key takeaways before clicking Save Changes. If you're not sure what they were, check how the story currently reads on the live homepage first. A fix is on the list.

Uploading Video and Thumbnails

Both uploaders work the same way — drag a file onto the dashed box, or click it to browse. There's an optional **File name** field above each box: fill it in with something readable like `john-doe-testimonial` and the file is saved under that name. Leave it blank and it gets an automatic name with a timestamp.

Upload	Accepted Formats	Size Limit
Video	MP4, WebM, MOV	100 MB
Thumbnail	PNG, JPG, WebP	5 MB

If a file with the same name already exists, the system doesn't overwrite it — it saves yours with a timestamp added so nothing is lost. If an upload fails you'll get a plain-language reason: too large, wrong format, no permission, or a network problem.

Once a video or thumbnail is attached, the form checks the link in the background and shows a red warning if it's broken — *"This URL is broken — visitors will see a black box."* Take that warning seriously; it means the file isn't where the record says it is. There's also a small preview of the video and the thumbnail right in the form, which is the fastest way to confirm you attached the right file to the right person.

Publishing, Drafting, and Archiving

- **Draft** — the working state. Not visible to the public.
- **Published** — eligible to appear on the website. It still has to be assigned to a section (or the section has to be left empty) before it actually shows up — see the Sections tab below.
- **Archived** — hidden from the website but kept in the system. Use this instead of deleting when a seller withdraws consent or a story is retired.

Deleting a Testimonial

Delete removes the story, its key takeaways, and the video and thumbnail files from storage. It is permanent and there is no undo. **Archive is almost always the right choice instead.** Only delete when

the record was created by mistake.

The Sections Tab — Choosing What Appears Where

The List tab decides which stories *exist*. The Sections tab decides which ones *appear*, and in what order. Switch between Spotlight, Featured, and Editorial at the top; each keeps its own list.

1 Add stories to the section

The right-hand **Available** column lists every published testimonial not yet in this section. Click the plus next to one to move it across. There's a search box if the list is long. Only published stories appear here — drafts and archived stories are not offered.

2 Put them in order

The left-hand **Assigned** column is numbered. Use the up and down arrows to reorder, and the X to remove a story from this section (removing it here does not delete the story — it stays in the List tab).

3 Check the preview

Below the two columns is a live preview of the actual section as it will appear on the site, rebuilt as you make changes. Use it to catch a missing thumbnail or an awkward order before anything ships.

4 Save

Save and Reset stay grayed out until you've actually changed something. Save writes the new order to the website. Reset throws away your unsaved changes and returns to the last saved arrangement.

> ***The empty-section rule:*** *if a section has nothing assigned to it, it does not disappear — it falls back to showing every published testimonial. So the way to control a section is to assign stories to it deliberately, not to leave it blank.*

What Visitors See When Something Goes Wrong

The website is built to degrade quietly rather than show a broken page. Worth knowing, because it means a problem can be live without looking obviously broken.

If this happens	The visitor sees
The video file is missing or unreachable	A small panel reading "Video unavailable — this clip is missing or unreachable," with a Retry button.
The thumbnail is missing	The seller's initial on a black background, with the play button moved to the corner. The video still plays.
A video story has no file and no YouTube link yet	A dashed placeholder reading "Video coming soon."
The database is unreachable	A small set of built-in backup stories, so the page never renders empty. These are not editable from the admin panel.

Quick Reference

Question	Where to Find the Answer
How do I add a new seller story?	Admin > Testimonials > List tab > New Testimonial
Why isn't my new testimonial on the site?	Check three things: status is Published, it's assigned in the Sections tab, and you're looking at the homepage (not About or a city page)
How do I change the order stories appear in?	Sections tab > pick the layout > up/down arrows > Save
How do I take a story down without losing it?	Set its status to Archived — never Delete
What size can a testimonial video be?	Up to 100 MB, as MP4, WebM, or MOV
How do I know a video link is broken?	The editor shows a red warning under the URL field, and the preview will fail to play
Where do the videos and images actually live?	Supabase storage — the `testimonial-videos` and `testimonial-thumbnails` buckets
Who has to approve a story before it's published?	Written seller consent on file first, then the standard review in the Research-First Process SOP

Known Issues — Read Before You Use This Module

These are confirmed and on the fix list. Until they're closed, work around them:

- **Editing wipes key takeaways.** The Points list opens empty on an existing story and saving clears it. Re-type the points every time you save.
- **Only star one testimonial as Featured.** Starring a second one breaks the Featured section silently — it stops showing the story you intended and falls back to something else, with no error message.
- **The Alice video on the live site is broken.** The record points at a file that isn't in storage, so visitors get the "Video unavailable" panel. The correct file and the seller's name both need confirming before it's republished.
- **The homepage stacking all three layouts is a test, not the design.** Don't treat it as final, and don't send it to anyone outside the team as-is.
- **Videos don't have captions yet.** Roughly 80% of viewers watch muted, and the SOP requires burned-in captions or on-screen text, so any new video should have captions burned into the file before upload.
- **The star rating always displays as 5.** The Rating field saves what you enter, but the website shows five stars regardless. Don't rely on it to communicate anything yet.
- **The Sections preview isn't perfectly accurate for Featured.** If a story is starred as Featured but not assigned to the Featured section, the live site may show it even though the preview doesn't.

This guide will be updated as each of these is resolved.